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Dan Barrett

Dan Barrett is a young instrumentalist who is keeping the tradition of classic jazz alive. He has become the premier trombonist of his generation. Since his start in the Los Angeles area in the 70s, he has performed and recorded with Benny Goodman, Woody Herman and the New York Pops Orchestra. His soloing and arranging can be heard on frequent recordings from Arbors Records. Dan was joined by his friend trumpet master Wendell Brunious for a conversation at the end of the interview.

Michael Woods interviewed Dan at the Los Angeles Classic Jazz Festival on September 3, 1995. Monk Rowe was also present for the interview.

MW: We are here today filming our Jazz Archives for Hamilton College. We have with us today a fabulous trombone player, Dan Barrett. Pleased to meet you.

DB: Same here.

MW: All right.

DB: Nice to be here.

MW: Tell us what brought you particularly to this festival of what they call classic jazz.

DB: Well actually I was born in this area, I'm originally from Southern California. I was born in Pasadena. I was about one year old when my parents moved to Costa Mesa in Orange County, and I grew up in the more traditional jazz scene, the Sunday afternoon Jazz Society meetings that are still held around Southern California, which is as much a social event for people as a musical event. The fellows we call "weekend warriors" will get out their horns and, you know, dust off their basses and that kind of thing, and have a good time playing the old Dixieland warhorses at these Sunday afternoon Jazz Society meetings. So that's what first got me interested in playing jazz, and that, I guess, accounts for why I've been invited to this festival. I think this is the third time I've done this now. I was here in 1987, then I had a few years off, and I was here last year and again this year.

MW: Marvelous. What led you to start playing the trombone other than any other instrument?

DB: Well, actually I wanted to play trumpet, and in fifth grade I remember very clearly a gentleman came in and our teacher introduced him and she said his name was Ken Owen, and he taught in the band at our local junior high school. And many of us would be graduating from the elementary school and going on to his junior high school. And he told us he had a concert band over at the junior high and that he was starting a beginning band program at the elementary school for fifth and sixth graders. And he made a little speech, parts of which I still remember. I was about eleven years old, and he told us, or I

whether we play music or not, that we're continually surrounded by music and he said many of you have parents who will play the radio when you're in the car and if you go shopping you hear music in the supermarket, and if you go to the dentist's office they usually have music playing. And he said of course there's background music for television shows. So he pointed out how big a part music plays in our everyday lives, and he said that he knew that some of us were probably thinking that we would like to try and make music ourselves instead of just listen to it, maybe some of us would like to try to play music ourselves. So he asked us to go home and talk it over with our parents, and he asked us to think about at least three instruments, three different instruments that we might want to play, because he thought that we might be more suited toward one instrument than the other. So the following week I came back. Mr. Owen led a bunch of us out of the class, so that was kind of exciting, we got out of the fifth grade class you know, to walk down to the auditorium. And he had several real instruments there and then to represent the instruments that he didn't have physically there he had pictures. So he brought pictures of French horns and violas and that kind of thing. And he asked us to sit by the picture of our first choice of instrument. So I went over and sat near a trumpet, because that's what I wanted to play. And he introduced himself to me and I told him my name and he kind of looked over my, they call it the embouchure, the lip muscles or chops we call them, and he said, "well gee, Danny, I don't know about playing trumpet. I think with your embouchure and the way your teeth are formed, you'd probably be better off playing the trombone." And I still have a healthy respect for Mr. Owen, but I found out a couple of years later, he had all the trumpet players he needed in the junior high band, and he didn't have any trombone players coming in. So he thought he'd cultivate a trombone player you see? And I finally got to seventh grade, I joined his band. He had about 15 trumpet players and three trombone players. And you know in the concert band, it's always the trumpets and sometimes the clarinets, but generally the trumpets that play the melodies to the songs. And what do the trombones do? They play the long whole notes in the background, making those guys sound good. You know what I mean. And after a couple of months of that, I told Mr. Owen I said, "I don't want to play these long boring notes, I want to play the melody. That's why I wanted to play music. So I want to play the trumpet." And he said, "well you know, Danny, he said, you can play the melody on trombone." I said, "no, no, no you can't." Because I didn't think you could. I'd never heard that done. And he said, "ask your parents if you can come in tomorrow morning early." I think class was at 8:00. He said, "come in at 7:30 and I'll play you some records of trombone players playing the melody." So I showed up at 7:30 and I'm sure Hamilton College is far better equipped than our junior high school, but do you remember those big

board, you know, they weighed a ton. Well he brought out one of those, and he had a couple of old 78s, and for our younger viewers, this is kind of funny. I never felt as old as I did when a student came over to my house for a lesson, and this young man was in his early 20s, and I wanted to play — I'm digressing but I'll get back — but I wanted to play him a record by Tommy Dorsey, and I went to my 78 collection and he said, "what are those? Is that a record?" And I said, "yes, it's a 78." And he said, "oh, far out, man, I've never seen one of those." And I thought God, I'm getting old. Anyway, so for our listeners, a 78 is an old, two-sided record, long before LPs they had 78s. They're real brittle and pretty fragile. Anyway that's what a 78 is. So anyway, Mr. Owen brought a couple of 78s by Tommy Dorsey and his orchestra, and he said, "Danny, you listen to this man, now he's going to play the melody on the trombone." And he put on this 78 and I can't remember the tune, it could have been Tommy Dorsey's theme song, "I'm Getting Sentimental Over You," something like that. And I'd never heard anything like that in my life, and for a while I thought Mr. Owen was putting me on, because I thought it was a French horn. I'd never heard a trombone played like that in my life you know. So he said, "see, if you practiced you could sound like that, and we'll have solos for you with the band and everything." So he convinced me into staying on the trombone for the concert band. But later on my folks got me a trumpet from a pawn shop, and Mr. Owen was a fairly accomplished Air Force trumpet player. So he agreed, he was a very kind man, he agreed to meet me after school and he gave me some trumpet lessons. So I wound up playing both of the instruments, although I played trombone in the school band, I played trumpet for fun with other groups.

MW: Well I think it's marvelous how somebody answers your questions and shows you the possibilities. You know, talk to us about how jazz improvisation shows us the innerds of the music.

DB: All right. Well about that same time that I discovered Tommy Dorsey, there was a jazz band playing at a pizza parlor in Huntington Beach. And my brother-in-law, who is a very good trumpet player here on the west coast, he and I often remarked how our musical lives would be different had we not gotten to hear that band. It's called the South Frisco Jazz Band. In fact, they're here at the festival this week. Their personnel has changed a little bit over the years, but they were playing Friday and Saturday nights at a pizza parlor which was great when you were in high school because the pizza parlor of course allowed minors you know. Moms and Dads would come in and have a pitcher of beer or something like that, and we'd have pizza and Coca Cola and hear this seven piece band and they were playing music that was foreign to us at the time, and we were amused by the names, because we'd never heard of guys like Jelly Roll Morton. We thought that

Orleans jazz every Friday and Saturday night we'd go over there. And you're talking about improvisation, we didn't understand how they were playing all this music without having any notes in front of them you know? And little by little we got to know the guys in the band and I think they were amused that a bunch of high school kids would think so much of them to show up every weekend. And during their breaks they'd sit and talk with us. And I remember the trombonist, who now plays with one of the Preservation Hall bands, his name is Frank Demond. And he was a building contractor in Southern California, and he used to go to New Orleans periodically, and his hero was Big Jim Robinson, a New Orleans trombonist who passed away several years ago. But Frank's style was very similar to Big Jim Robinson's and when Big Jim started getting ill, Frank would fly to New Orleans and sub for him. So these guys were not, they may have had day jobs, but they were terrific musicians, and Frank actually later gave up a building contractor job in Southern California to move to New Orleans to play with the Preservation Hall Band. Anyway, he was very generous with his time, and on the breaks he would show me musical things like the cycle of fifths and how one chord leads to another chord and took a whole lot of time explaining that to all of us, our little group of high school musicians. We had a Dixieland band in high school, and we tried to copy, as best we could by ear, what the guys were doing at that pizza parlor, and we tried it at our own rehearsals and wondered why it didn't sound as good somehow. And I remember our very first job, we got hired to play a party down in Newport Beach. And we knew seven songs. And they had us playing from eight at night until four the next morning, when the party finally broke up. And we played these seven songs over and over again. And the great thing about is about four of them were blues in B flat. I don't know what the other three were. We got paid five dollars each. And I thought, God this is great. An actual five dollar bill for playing music. I thought, you know, I'm on my way, this is wonderful. And then I kind of promised myself, I'll never spend this, I'm going to keep this forever. And then I went to the Pizza Palace and blew it on pizza or something.

MW: Talk about classic jazz, that's classic. Tell us about some of your work with some of the famous big bands.

DB: Oh, gee, well I haven't really played with that many big bands. I was lucky enough, I will sound like I'm dropping a name, but I'm real proud to drop this name, I was lucky enough to play with Benny Goodman for the last seven months of his life. And he had just put a big band back together again. He continued playing all through the 60s and 70s and 80s, but mostly with smaller groups. He'd have maybe a trumpet and sax and a rhythm section you know. But toward the end of his life he decided to put together a big band. And it's kind of funny how it worked out, because maybe he knew that he didn't

international prominence, and in a way his life kind of went full circle because he went right back to the same music, the same Fletcher Henderson arrangements that first gained him national attention. So it was maybe the most exciting seven months in my life. And I've described it as being, you know people ask what it's like playing for Benny Goodman and it's equal measures of excitement and terror.

MW: Describe that for us. Kind of give us a hypothetical.

DB: Well his standards were so high. In fact one trumpet player at the trumpet player's first rehearsal, I think I'd made two or three rehearsals, this trumpet player came in and we finished the rehearsal and ran to the nearest bar I think, the whole band, en masse. The trumpet player was shaking his head and I said, "John, what's wrong?" He said, "I can't figure this guy out." I said, "who, Goodman?" He said, "yeah." I said, "well what can't you figure out?" And he said, "well he wants everything to swing, but he wants it perfect, but he wants it to swing, but he wants it perfect." And I said, "yeah." And he said, "well I'm used to like laid back band leaders. They don't care about everything being precise as long as it swings." And he says, "I've worked for other band leaders, they don't want to know about swinging, they want every note perfectly in place." He said, "this guy wants both." And I said, "yeah, that's why he's Benny Goodman." And he didn't ask us to do anything that he wasn't doing himself. I mean he worked the hardest at his age. He was in his middle 70s then and he'd, he was famous for this, and it was true, I'd read about this and then finally he did it with us. He would have the whole band there, and then he'd tell the rhythm section to get lost for 45 minutes. He'd say, "go off and get some coffee and come back in 45 minutes or an hour. Take an hour off." And the guys in the rhythm section shrugged their shoulders and take off, so that left the saxophone section and the trumpets and trombones. And he'd say, "okay, start it at the top, one, two, one two three." And the first time we did this, we came in and the rhythm fell back, almost imperceptibly. But he waved us off and he said, "no, that isn't where I kicked it off. Now do it again." And it was a little frightening, a little intimidating you know? "One, two, one two three" and we came in again and we got through about 16 bars then before it — hey Wendell — before it settled down a little bit. And he waved us off again you know. And he said, "I'm not going to play with a band that can't keep time. Now do it again, and this time keep time." You know, "okay." And he kicked it off again, and we got through the first chorus, and he said, "keep going." Now this is with no rhythm section you know. And there were places where the piano would normally play fills, well those were just big open spaces. And he said, "no foot tapping — I don't want to hear anybody count — count in your mind." And we kept going and then finally there was a bridge. And we were all frightened to death but we were keeping it going, and there was a bridge

eight bars like this silently, and then we came in [snaps fingers] about like that, I mean almost exactly but not quite, and we thought he was going to bite our heads off and he started laughing. He thought that was pretty funny. Because he knew how difficult that was.

MW: There is a concept behind that, could you elaborate on that a little bit, that is the whole concept of as a jazz musician, having to internalize time.

DB: Yes, well it's like a clock. You have to keep it going regardless of what's going on around you and the best — the jazz musicians that I idolize and time recognizes, or the passage of time recognizes these people as being the best jazz musicians, and I'm thinking of Louis Armstrong and Charlie Parker, Lester Young and of course the great drummers, Jo Jones and Sid Catlett and Philly Joe Jones and John Coltrane, I don't know, but they all, oh and Sidney Bechet, I was just listening to Sidney Bechet. He had a very strong sense of time. And he could, like the best New Orleans players, one of which is sitting across the room from us, Wendell Brunious, Bechet could play with the time as did Louis, as did Parker, as did all the great jazz musicians, where it wasn't just playing behind the beat or on the beat, or in front of the beat, they had complete control of the beat. And some phrases would come out ahead, some phrases would come out behind, but they were all exactly where they wanted to put them. It's kind of remarkable, even in the 20s, Bechet was probably closest to Louis I think as far as that goes. There are some breaks, I think it's "Cake Walking Babies From Home," one of the old recordings, where the rhythm section stops and there are breaks, and Louis takes the initial breaks and then Bechet comes in later, and it's just astonishing what he was doing with the time, even that early. How grounded his sense of time was. So, you know, I don't know if I've adequately described internalizing time, but you just have to keep that clock going, regardless of what you hear around you you know. And sometimes, especially at festivals like this, it's almost impossible what they ask musicians to do. To get up on the stage, having never played with each other before you know, and to try and have some semblance of a beat there. To try and get four guys who have never even played before, or never even met, thinking and feeling the time the same way. You know it's nearly an impossible task and it's remarkable it comes out as well as it does. But sometimes things get a little shifty back there and you just have to keep that clock going in your head.

MW: Talk to us about playing the trombone, and how you try to impose your will over perhaps an imprecise instrument.

DB: Well, remember I always wanted to play the trumpet and in recent years I'm starting to play more and more cornet actually. But I try to approach the trumpet, or I try to approach the trombone more like a trumpet. And Louis is my big hero actually. If I had to

know, I mean there are so many guys I love, but Louis is number one. And I keep thinking about him and I keep thinking about playing as simply as I can. And this may be something that comes with age. I remember when I was 15 trying to do everything under the sun. And I was about 18 when I heard my first Charlie Parker record and — well no I can't say that, I guess I was in high school — and I just didn't get it. I really didn't get it. And some students then in college, they said, "Hey Dan, I hear you're monkeying around with some different things, maybe you're ready to try Charlie Parker again." And they put on this record and I thought oh, now I see. Oh, now I see what's up here you know. And then like everybody who hears Charlie Parker for the first time, I went home and I was playing with a Dixieland band at the time. And we'd call these traditional jazz tunes and it came to my solo and I'd try and play what I just heard on the Charlie Parker record with a banjo and tuba. You know, these guys are rolling their eyes, like well when's Dan going to get out of this phase? And I was bopping my little heart out. But then I'd get tapes that people would make of the band, and I'd think boy, that really isn't me. It doesn't sound, I don't know, that isn't how I'm meant to play. And there was, I don't know, at some point there came this realization that I can love Charlie Parker as much as anybody, and yet maybe I'm not cut out to play like that you know. And I still have, I don't know if I have everything he recorded, but I have a significant portion of my collection is Parker. And some days I'll wake up and I'll feel like playing Charlie Parker, and other days I'll wake up and feel like playing the King Oliver records, I don't know. But you just have to find your own way. And I think the trombone, it makes more sense when it's played simply. And that's not to discredit all the great trombonists who are far better technical virtuosos than I am, but it just seems more personal to me when I can pare my ideas down and just kind of take my time and collect my thoughts you know. And the trombone seems to be more sensible then, or more musical you know. You can get away with faster playing on the saxophone and piano. Those instruments seem to lend themselves more to, to more technical virtuosity. With the trombone, I think it just sounds better to the ears played in a simpler manner. And the guys I think about, oh that kind of golden age of trombone players, there was Lawrence Brown with the Duke Ellington Orchestra, he had just a gorgeous sound and a great sense of swing. There's Vic Dickinson and going back further, J.C. Higginbotham. My dad had some 78s around the house, I really don't know why because he wasn't a jazz fan per se, but I think he just liked music and he brought a couple of 78s back from the war and one of them featured J.C. Higginbotham on trombone. That was another great name when you were in high school and you see J.C. Higginbotham, you think who is this guy? I want to know more about him. And he had a great big broad, dark sound. I tried to emulate him for a while,

the first half of your career you spend trying to sound like other guys and then the second half, if you're smart, you spend it trying not to sound like those guys. You're just trying to find your own voice.

MW: As a parting question, if you had a word of wisdom to give to students that you know will be watching this tape, students trying to make their way in the profession of jazz and understand the idiom, just a parting shot.

DB: Yeah, I actually think I have something pertinent to say. I would advise them that in their practicing as they're playing scales and as they're playing exercises and trying to improve their technique, I would take about 25 or 30 percent of that time, or a margin of that practice time and use it to study songs. And go out and buy sheet music, not just lead sheets with the chord symbols, but shell out the bucks that it takes and go out and buy Cole Porter songs and go out and buy George Gershwin songs you know. And look at them and look at the piano parts, even if you don't play piano. And it takes forever, I mean if you're not a piano player, but it's worth the effort to sit at a keyboard and hear how those inner voices move. And if you spent, or if the student spent a little bit of his time, his practice time, doing that, analyzing these songs by these great songwriters he'd learn how to construct a line. Because after all these are great composers you know. And what we're trying to do in jazz ostensibly is to compose, even though we're composing spontaneously.

MW: Instant composition.

DB: We're trying to compose. And I think what better way to learn to compose then examining music by a great composer. So not only would you profit from that knowledge that you can gain by analyzing that music, but also you'll learn these great songs that people like to hear played. I've said this before too. I tell students this. Once student said, "well Mr. Barrett, this is all well and good, but when are we going to get into the lydian modes and all of that?" And I say, well I said, "somebody else can teach you that better than I can," and I said, "I think any knowledge is good." And I said, "it'd probably benefit you greatly to know about that." But I said, "I'll tell you something. Playing in clubs, I've received five dollars here and there to play 'Body and Soul' and I've received ten dollar tips to play 'Stardust' and I've gotten a couple of bucks to play 'Shanty in an Old Shantytown' for people." But I said, "I don't think I've ever made a dime to play a lydian mode for anybody. You know? No one has ever come up and requested a dorian mode or a lydian mode. You know? So it's great to know about that stuff, but I think you'd be better off, you know I'm addressing students now, I think you'd be much better off and stand a much greater chance to make a living in a fairly competitive business if you learn these songs and learn them correctly, and you can play them so you make

MW: That's wonderful.

DB: All right. Thank you. This has been a pleasure.

MW: Oh, it's been great. Thank you.

MR: We had an idea here, if you have another ten minutes, to let you two guys talk.

DB: All right. We're on speaking terms.

[pause]

DB: Well I guess we're on camera. My name is Dan Barrett and I'm privileged and honored to introduce a very good friend of mine and a terrific trumpet player from New Orleans, Mr. Wendell Brunious.

WB: Thank you, Daniel.

DB: You're welcome.

WB: I was sitting there in admiration of your comments, especially about Louis Armstrong, who, without him, I really don't know what position jazz would be — I don't know if there would even be jazz actually.

DB: Well I know you'll agree it's kind of sad that even accomplished, even many accomplished jazz musicians don't fully understand what Louis did for the music you know. And they give him a lot of lip service and say oh Pops, oh yeah, Satchmo, yeah Louis, yeah, right. And I don't think that many of them have actually checked out those records.

WB: I agree with you.

DB: But if you think about it, like for instance when Louis was with Fletcher Henderson's band in the early 20s, and he turned everybody around just like Charlie Parker did later. And everybody wanted to be like Louis Armstrong. And I read, you probably read this, like Rex Stewart went out and got a pair of clunky shoes like Louis used to wear. And Rex said, "yeah I used to try to walk like him and dress like him and play like him and I wanted to be him."

WB: They tell me when Louis went to Chicago he had like a box back coat, which had gone out of style, and everybody started wearing box back coats. I probably would have done it myself when you think about it.

DB: But that band changed after Louis was in it, the Henderson band. All of a sudden, I mean you hear the records before he came into the band and if it was swinging, it wasn't swinging in the way it was after Louis was there.

WB: I agree with you.

DB: And then the whole big band era. See people don't, they don't give Louis credit. He kind of founded the swing era. Because Fletcher started writing those arrangements. We were talking about Benny Goodman earlier. And Fletcher Henderson started writing

Fletcher would do that made those arrangements so great, is he was writing, phrasing, like Louis would play. They were pop tunes from the day, but Fletcher Henderson would sit there and imagine, now how would Louis play this phrase. So he'd write for five brass.

WB: That's a strong impact on everything.

DB: Well that's enough about him. Let's talk about you.

WB: I just want to say this. I heard a professor one time, and he said, "Oh, yeah, Louis Armstrong. The guy would sometimes play a whole solo with one note." Oh yeah? And I mean it's horrible to hear something like that because this is a guy that's teaching young people hopefully to play jazz. And if you don't teach someone to respect and investigate Louis Armstrong, I don't think you're teaching them the right thing. Because he was a force to be reckoned with, to say the very least.

DB: My brother-in-law, I don't think you've met him, Ryan Shaw is his name. He's a real good trumpet player from the west coast. A few years ago I was at his house and he had this, well it was a textbook and it was a real dry textbook. I can't remember the exact title, but it was something like Principles of Brass Playing in the Modern Orchestra. And it was talking about symphonic brass playing. And I said, "what should I see about this," because it looked pretty boring, a big textbook. He said, "well look up, I think it's page 288. I opened it up and the heading was "Vibrato." And in very formal language, by a professor or something, it said something about the use of vibrato was shunned in symphonic works, and it was forbidden to use vibrato until the middle to late 1930s. And at that time, and there it is in print, it said there was a trumpet player from New Orleans, Louis Armstrong, who exerted such an overwhelming influence on brass players that the judicious use of vibrato is today accepted, at the composer's discretion, or at the conductor's discretion. I said wow, you know, so we're not just talking about jazz, we're talking about brass playing, and people don't understand that Louis was — well I've heard this about Louis, have you heard this? Oh, yeah, he couldn't read too well. You know, come on. He was sight reading those things? Studio dates every day? Sight singing too, not sight playing. And he was on a first name basis with the principal trumpet players of the orchestras around the country. Well that's enough about Louis Armstrong.

WB: Not enough can be said about Louis Armstrong, let's face it. My daughter has a little friend in New Orleans and the little friend's babysitter, once I went to pick them up to take them for a cool drink or something. And the lady gets in the car and she says, "you're a jazz musician, right?" I say, "yeah." She says, "you know my cousin played trumpet." I say, "really, who is it?" She says, "Louis Armstrong." Armstrong, man, I got the shakes man.

WB: You know, you'd think Joe Smooth or somebody you know. Louis Armstrong. That may be enough about Louis even though not enough can be said.

DB: I just want to ask you did you ever hear him in person?

WB: No. I saw him one time but I never really heard him in person.

DB: Yeah, I never did either. I've had real vivid dreams about him.

WB: I'll bet.

DB: Kind of funny, like hearing him play in these dreams. And he talked to me. Oh it was really weird. And he did it with Jon Kellso too, the young trumpet player in New York. Kellso had a similar dream. Like it makes me cry to think about it. He said he was sitting on a park bench and he saw Louis sitting on this other park bench, and then Louis got up in this dream and walked over the just sat down by him and took his hand and just kind of patted his hand. Like, you know, don't worry about a thing, everything's going to be all right. Crazy. Weird.

WB: That's got to be like the best dream you could have I think. When I was a little kid, it was about 1963 or something like that, Louis Armstrong came to New Orleans. And this big brass band like George Lewis and Punch Miller and my dad and everybody went out there to meet Louis. And my dad told my brother and I said, "look, get some clothes on, I'm going to take you someplace" you know and we were wondering where we were going. He said, "I'm going to take you see Louis Armstrong." I really didn't think I would see Louis Armstrong. But we went to the airport and when Louis stepped out of the plane, man that band hit — boom. And a smile came over Louis' face. He had a white baseball cap on and it was just something I could never forget. And he rubbed me on the head like that. Hey Pops. That was one of the greatest moments of my life.

DB: I'll bet.

WB: I mean we keep saying this enough about Louis Armstrong, but we keep going.

DB: Well if anything, I hope all this talk, whoever might see this, if they haven't examined those records, and it doesn't matter, it doesn't matter what record, if he's on it, it's going to be great.

WB: That's right.

DB: It doesn't matter whether it's the 20s or the 30s or 40s or 50s or 60s.

WB: And what timing man. That's one thing that you could get from Louis Armstrong, listening to him. The timing. Because I mean, you know he had it. He created it basically. But any-way. What else do you talk about after Louis Armstrong? Louis Armstrong is God I guess. Also, when you were saying with the young players, when he was asking about trying to get them, what would you advise them about learning to play jazz, and you made such a strong statement about learning melodies. Because and you even said

my definition — and Webster didn't have anything to do with this one — but I thought it was kind of think of it as a series of notes that tie some changes together. And that's basically what a solo is.

DB: That's right.

WB: So I mean to learn melodies, which I don't think we accentuate upon them enough in the schools. I mean my dad had recorded a record with Paul Barbarin in the 1950s and one of the cuts on there was "Bourbon Street Parade" which Paul Barbarin wrote. And what my dad used to do was he'd tell us "I'm going out for a while, and I want you to learn like Bob Thomas' solo on 'Bourbon Street Parade.'" And as a result of that I can hum that solo right now, you know? That had that kind of impact on me. And you know I mean I'm not a real older style player, in fact still, it's in me.

DB: You don't think so, huh?

WB: Well I mean, but it's like you know that's really maturing type of tactics and things to do that help you to mature faster. I think so.

DB: I do too. I didn't know anything about improvising when I first heard these jazz records. I didn't know they were making it up out of their heads. I just liked the music, you know. And then I remember hearing a Bix Beiderbecke record and reading all the critics or the writers you know they say the same thing. I think one guy reads something and then he recycles it you know. But everything I read about Bix Beiderbecke, they said he was fond of ninths and thirteenths. I thought oh well, that's nice. And then the next writer would say oh he likes ninths and thirteenths. And then I heard some record, I think it was "Somebody Stole My Gal," and Bix plays this real nice phrase, and he went down to this kind of unusual note that rubbed up against the root of the chord. And I thought gee that sounds real strange but it sounds real good and real right. And then finally I was, you know, the light came on that I should start playing a little more piano or trying to find out about the keyboard, which is some other advice we could give to students. You know even if you haven't studied piano formally, just get acquainted with the keyboard so you can see chords and learn about changes. And I went over to the keyboard and I finally found out what chord that was, and then I realized it was like an E flat seventh, and Bix had gone down to an F. And I thought well that's one, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight, nine. Oh, that's a ninth. Oh that's a ninth. Oh, yeah. You know, light — 20 watt light bulb. Oh that's what a ninth is. And I went nine, ten, eleven, twelve, thirteen, oh, that's a thirteenth. Oh, yeah, I've heard him do that. And then of course, as I mentioned, when I first heard Charlie Parker and I go back to my Dixieland band and try and play like Charlie Parker. Well then every solo I played, I went immediately for the ninth. Banjo player's "Come on, Dan." Ninth, ninth, ninth.

DB: Oh, the heck with it. We'll just stay here, send out for pizza. Do you have anything to tell the camera?

WB: Well I've got so much respect for Dan Barrett that I would tend to listen to you, Dan.

DB: Thank you. You know the feeling is mutual, and it has been a long time.

WB: Thank you man.

DB: Nice to have this little chat. We should do this more often. Maybe we'll get our own talk show.

WB: Hey, everybody's got 'em.